THE OBJECTIVE LEDGER · BOOK 3

Sharing the load

The work nobody sees, and a fair, kind way to share it



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

The Objective Ledger, Book 3. Sharing the load.
By Christian. Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

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Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. Blank copies, with room to write, are in *The Workbook*; you can also fill them in free on the website.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Chat analyzer”. You use it and it gives you something back.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12, page **121** says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16 (online) about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 1 · ONLINE: PREFACE TO PART TWO

The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home

Part Two of the book is about the people you share a life, a home or a job with, and it opens here. Running a life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This preface helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so you can talk about it fairly and kindly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your own unseen work
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. Where this comes from: the polymath way
14. In real life
15. More kinds of shared life
16. Your situation, in this part of the book
17. Common mix-ups
18. Limits and cautions

IN SHORT:

- **Running a home takes unseen work:** the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.

- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature. It isn't a sign that they don't care.
- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- **The list is for seeing, not for billing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

Someone notices the laundry is still in the washer, the school forms are due on Tuesday, and the birthday card never got posted. They also notice that nobody else has noticed. The house looks fine. That's the problem.

Or, living alone: A widower says, "Since my wife died, I notice how many jobs she quietly carried: the birthday cards, the boiler service, knowing who to ring when someone was ill. I never saw them until they stopped getting done."

01

Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing the milk is low, calming a tense moment: none of it shows up on a calendar, so it rarely gets a thank-you. Over months, it piles up. The book calls this pile *unbilled debt*. Nobody sends a bill for it. You can thank someone for what they carried before; you just don't bill for the past.

For example: Marcus remembers every school form, dentist visit and bit of lunch money for their two kids. His husband, Theo, sees two kids who always seem to have what they need. The work is just out of sight.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can I show you some of the things I keep track of? I'm not asking you to pay anything back. I just want you to see them."

TRY THIS:

Tonight, write down three things you did today that nobody saw. Don't do anything with the list yet. Just notice.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The easiest way to see unseen work is to write it down for one ordinary week. Each of you logs only your own jobs, and the thinking counts too.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

02

A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy, even though nobody can see it.

For example: In a shared flat, Yasmin notices the internet deal is ending, compares plans, picks one and checks it went through. Paying took two minutes. The thinking took an evening.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Doing it is the quick part. Remembering it and planning it is the part I'd love some help with."

TRY THIS:

Pick one job at home and split it into four steps: notice, plan, do, check. Who usually does each step?

The work nobody sees

Most of a job happens before and after the doing.

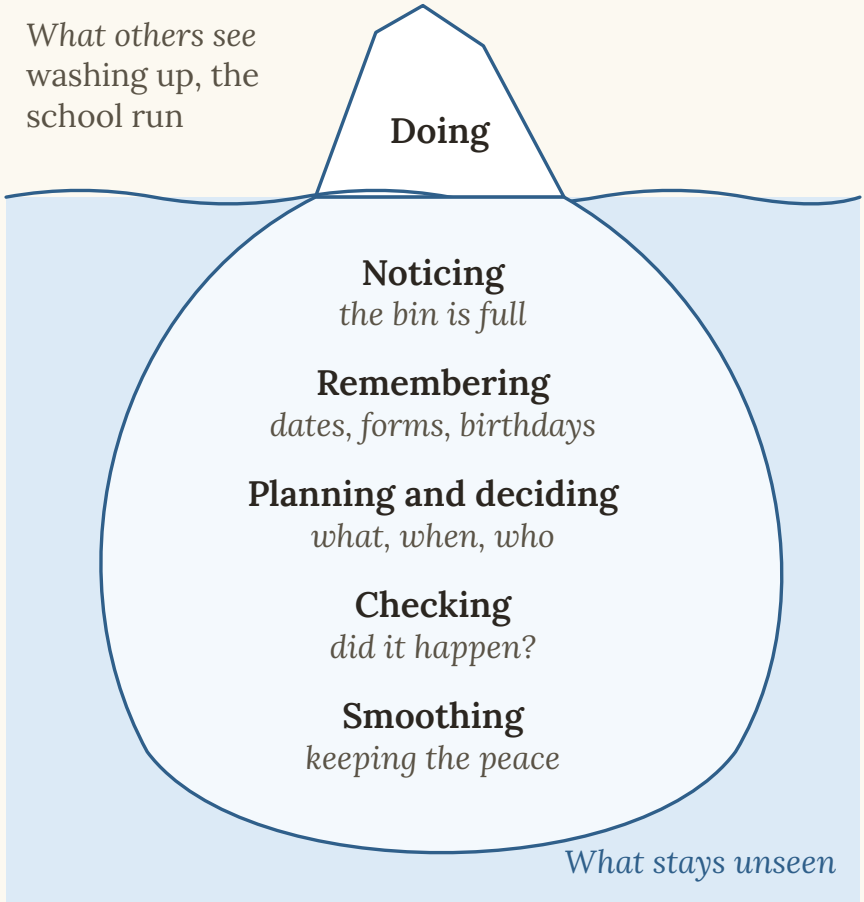


Illustration. The five kinds are this book's plain words; researchers call the thinking part "cognitive labour" (Daminger, 2019).

FIGURE 1 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen. So the other person isn't ignoring it. From where they stand, it looks like things take care of themselves.

For example: Edna minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own doctor visits to fit. Her daughter thinks it all "fits in easily."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think you've been ignoring it. I think it's been hard to see from where you are."

TRY THIS:
Ask one person, "What's something you do that you think I don't see?" Then just listen, without explaining.

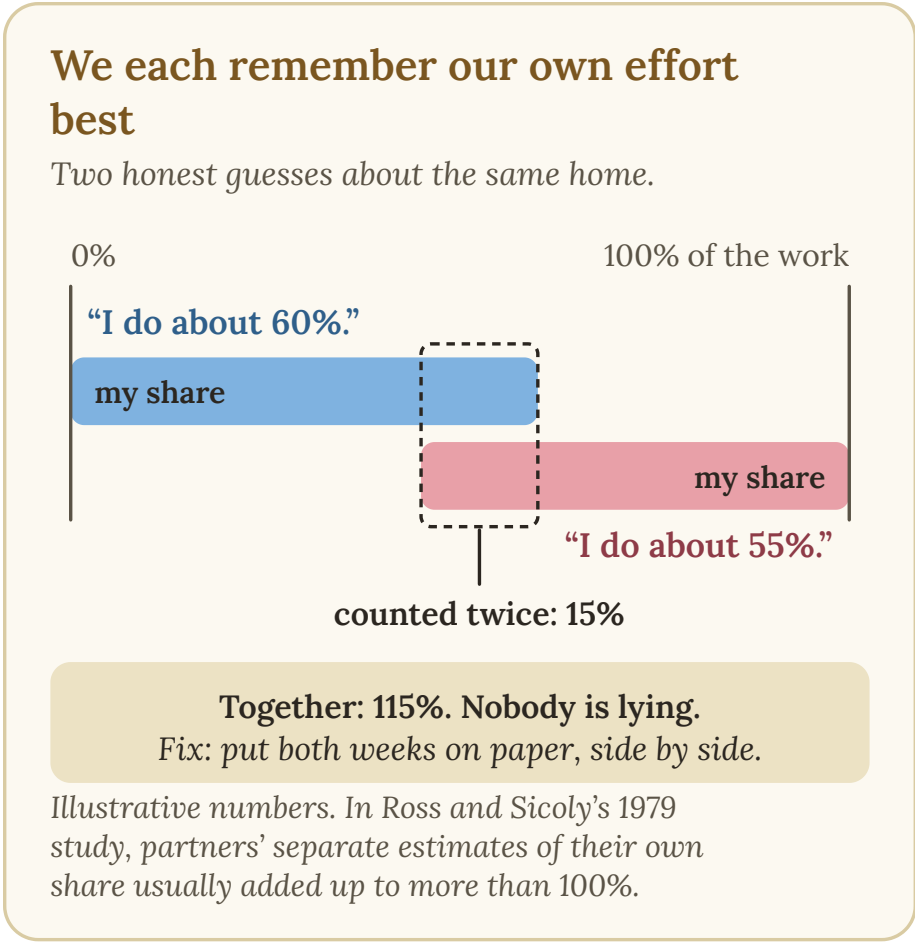


FIGURE 2 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers; in Ross and Sicoly’s 1979 study, partners’ estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

Writing it down isn’t keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time. Then the talk starts from facts you share, not from two different memories.

The book calls this shared record a *ledger*: a plain list of who did what. It’s a way to see, not a bill.

For example: Two coworkers sharing one job each list a week of tasks. Every client call landed on one person. They don't argue about last year; they swap Friday calls.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm not trying to win anything. I'd like us both to be looking at the same list."

TRY THIS:

Before you show anyone a list, ask yourself: is this to plan next week, or to prove a point? Share it only if the answer is "plan."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

Who did what

Marcus and Theo, a couple

Who did what

Person A
Marcus

Person B
Theo

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Plan the week's meals*	*Theo*	*20*	*Thinking and planning*
Mon	*Cook dinner*	*Marcus*	*45*	*Asked for*
Tue	*Book the boiler service*	*Theo*	*15*	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Dishes*	*Marcus*	*20*	*Asked for*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Wed	*Laundry, wash to put away*	*Theo*	*60*	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Remember Marcus's mum's birthday card*	*Theo*	*10*	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Bins and recycling out*	*Marcus*	*10*	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Big food shop*	*Both*	*70*	*Asked for*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Marcus
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

Theo
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

Workload balance score
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

A *made-up example. Names and details are invented.*

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

05

Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did, then read the two lists together. That keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, like what the week was like, so you both understand rather than judge.

For example: Arran, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a home. Each writes only their own list. Reading them together, Sol learns Arran has been calling the landlord every month.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I've written my side. Would you like to write yours, in your own words, when you're ready?"

TRY THIS:
Add one line of context to your own list, like "long week at work" or "the kids were ill." It helps the other person understand, not judge.

06

The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what's happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here.

For example: Two brothers share their mum's care. Instead of "you never help," one says, "There's some unseen work here we haven't looked at." That's much easier to hear.

New together? If words like "ledger" or "debt" feel heavy a few months in, use your own. "Our list" and "the stuff nobody sees" work just as well. The idea stays the same: two people looking at one honest picture, kindly, so nobody has to guess.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Let's look at how it's set up, not at each other."

TRY THIS:

Swap one blaming phrase you use, like "you never," for a plain one, like "this job keeps landing on me."

07

One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool. One week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying today, a weekly catch-up and a monthly look-back. If you use the monthly look-back later, a few lines a week is all it needs.

For example: A nurse on nights and a partner on days hardly see each other awake. They start with one week of notes on the fridge. No changes yet.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Could we just try one week of notes and see what we notice? We don't have to change anything yet."

TRY THIS:

Pick a start day this week and set one reminder on your phone. That's the whole first step.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: counting jobs isn't keeping score. It's more like a treasure hunt for the work nobody noticed! The quick split check is a good first sniff.

TOOL **Who does what: chore split check** ·
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`

08

It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, family, roommates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, but the ideas fit anyone who shares a load.

For example: A foster carer tracks family visits, social worker calls and school meetings. A teenager in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week. Both count.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Whatever we are to each other, we share some work. Could we look at it together?"

TRY THIS:

Name one shared load in your life that isn't a couple: a family group chat, a shared flat, a team at work.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back towards your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly. You think: someone did. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked like it took care of itself.

The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**: the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done, and the checking after. Knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes. Remembering the form, the jab, the party present. It's real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby, a gap often opens: in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to. Researchers call it *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in, and lets them do it their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, not a verdict on yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women. That's why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper, instead of guessing.

For example (made up): Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even. But Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter II (page 43).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of: whole jobs, start to finish." Or, the other way round: "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Notice everything you carry, including the thinking and feeling work you have never counted. Notice, too, the work others do that you may have missed.
- **Between you and others:** Put both lists on one shared, fair page, so nobody has to argue about whose work "counts." Jobs nobody claims tend to drift to whoever notices first, and a specific thank-you helps keep things steady.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I want to see what you carry, too, not just what I carry." "Could we put both our weeks on one page?"

On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing the unseen. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember: the appointments, the restocking, the smoothing-over. Write them down for yourself, not as a bill.

- Count it, don't charge it. The point is to see your real load, so you can plan your energy.
- Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which just landed on you.
- Pick one job you could hand back, drop or do less often, and say so kindly.

For example: Nicola, divorced, has the children every other week. On paper, she sees she still buys presents for both sides of the family. She hands his side back, kindly, in one message.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I've noticed I've been doing this for both of us. From next month, could you take it on?" Or, to yourself: "That was real work, even if nobody saw it."

TRY THIS:
Circle one job on your list that is yours by choice. Enjoy it. Then circle one that just landed on you, and decide what you'll do about it. More for people living alone or after a breakup: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:
Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: your circle of control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

Christian, who wrote this book, worked as a government auditor and is a polymath: someone who studied thirteen fields deeply (psychology, philosophy, behavioural science, neurobiology, economics, business, finance, holistic therapies, aromatherapy, the art of debating, politics, music and the healing power of laughter). This chapter grows from 5 of them:

- **Finance** (See the whole load): The idea of an unbilled hour: work that was done and logged, but never invoiced, so the client never sees it.

- **Economics** (See the whole load): Attention is limited. Every reminder you hold in your head takes up some of it.
- **Psychology** (See the whole load): We remember our own effort best.
- **Philosophy** (See the whole load): Telling what we know from how things look. In Plato's Cave, people mistake shadows for the real thing.
- **Business** (Notice the quiet incentives): Work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it lands on whoever notices first.

Two fields, one idea: Finance + Psychology. In double-entry bookkeeping, every amount is recorded in two places, and the two must agree. And we each remember our own effort best. Put together: each person keeps their own record, and the two records are read side by side.

Where this comes from: the polymath way

This book is built on a polymath's habit: looking at very different fields and noticing that the same few roots keep turning up. Those roots are balance, signal and noise, feedback loops, limited capacity, ownership, quiet incentives, and state and setting. A ledger, a nervous system and a conversation look nothing alike, yet each one has a limit, each one can lose a message in the noise, and each one stays steady only when what goes out is matched by what comes back.

Christian saw those roots across thirteen fields. The four newest to the list are the art of debating, politics, music and the healing power of laughter. They shape the gentler parts of the book: how to disagree without a fight, how a small group decides fairly, how tone and tempo change what lands, and how a shared laugh can repair a hard moment.

Read the polymath way · See how every field connects to every other

In real life

- **Partners:** One of you keeps track of birthdays, presents and thank-you notes for both families. The other has never had to think about it.
- **Family:** One grown-up child handles a parent's appointments and prescription refills each week. The others see a parent who is "doing fine."
- **Roommates:** One roommate always buys the toilet paper and the dish soap. Nobody asked them to. It just keeps happening.
- **Coworkers:** One person books the meetings, takes the notes and follows up afterwards. It isn't in anyone's job description.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I didn't know you did that. Thank you." "Can we look at who does the remembering, not just the doing?"

More kinds of shared life

Unseen work turns up wherever people share something:

- **Two mums:** one holds the baby's dates and forms in her head; the other does lots of hands-on care.
- **More than two partners:** a job nobody owns lands on whoever notices first. More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two)
- **Friends:** one friend always makes the plans and sends the "how are you?" Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Teens:** walking the dog and minding a sister feels like a lot to them, and like "helping a bit" to adults. For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Grandparents and grown-up children:** childcare comes with planning work, too. Grown-up children

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)

- **Adult siblings:** one sorts a late parent's paperwork for months. Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Co-parents and carers:** packing the right kit for two homes; meetings and reports on top of care. Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Foster and kinship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **Housemates, coworkers and business partners:** one person always notices the bathroom, or chases the invoices. Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **Illness, different hours, distance, two faiths:** the one at home more, or the one who is well, becomes the default; the ill partner manages unseen pain and energy. When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't need it to be even. I need it to be seen."

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) · How it fits your relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/relationships).

Your situation, in this part of the book

Some situations get their own section in Part Two:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws:** Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1)
- **Small children or a new baby:** Chapter II (page 43)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents:** Chapter III (page 68)
- **Money between you:** Chapter IV (page 92)

- **A couple and a housemate:** Chapter IV (page 93)
- **New together, or about to move in:** Chapter V (page 114)
- **Grandparents raising a grandchild:** Chapter V (page 114)

Common mix-ups

- **"If it mattered, they would have asked for help."** Unseen work is often hidden from the person doing it, too, until it's written down.
- **"Writing it down means I'm angry."** It means you want you both to see the same picture.
- **"It has to be exactly 50/50."** The goal is a split you can both see and both agree to, not a perfect half.
- **"Mental work doesn't count, only chores do."** Remembering, planning and checking take real time and energy. Put them on the list.
- **"We should start by going over the last ten years."** Start with one ordinary week. You can thank someone for the past without trying to settle it.
- **"The one doing less doesn't care."** Usually they just can't see it yet. Nobody here is the villain. Once you've both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think either of us is the bad guy here. We just haven't seen the same picture yet."

TRY THIS:

Each of you, on your own, list the things you did this week that nobody saw. Then swap lists.

Next, read the other list slowly and say one thing on it you hadn't noticed before.

Then pick one item from their list and say thank you for it, in a specific way.

If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a cup of coffee with the same questions works too.

Keep it light. This is a first look, not a verdict. The fixing comes later in the book.

Limits and cautions

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A list should never be demanded, checked over your shoulder, or used to keep track of where you go or what you spend. If that is happening, it isn't a ledger. It's control, and it's not your fault. Signs to look out for. If you are a counsellor or group leader using this book with others, see For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Running a home takes unseen work:** the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- ✓ **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature. It isn't a sign that they don't care.
- ✓ **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- ✓ **The list is for seeing, not for billing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Is the split working? page 27
Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust

Book 2 · How we see each other Together
Why each person sees their own work first

Chapter 6 · Helping others well page 121
Care work and how not to burn out

Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair page 73
What fair means to each of you, before you talk

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface-in-depth

2

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 2 · ONLINE: PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: is your own load working?
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Small children and a new baby
16. If only one of you wants to try this
17. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Look at the month, not last night.** Use what you both wrote down, not memory.
- **Three things go in:** balance (how the hours split), ownership (does each job have a name?) and stress (how full each tank is).
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.

- **It judges the setup, never a person.** It's where a talk starts, not how one ends.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about. When the other one says it feels even, they mean it. From inside each person's own week, it does.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask "Is this working?", the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Re-ask it every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

For example: Two housemates had one awful week of dishes. The whole month showed three fine weeks and one exam week.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we look at the whole month before we decide anything?"

TRY THIS:

Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: one bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with a snack.

TOOL **Fair split calculator** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working`

02

Three things go in.

How evenly the hours are shared. Whether every regular job has a clear owner (the job list, One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job)). And how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on.

A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start. Rough notes on paper work too.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

TRY THIS:
Open the three worksheets once, just to see what they ask.

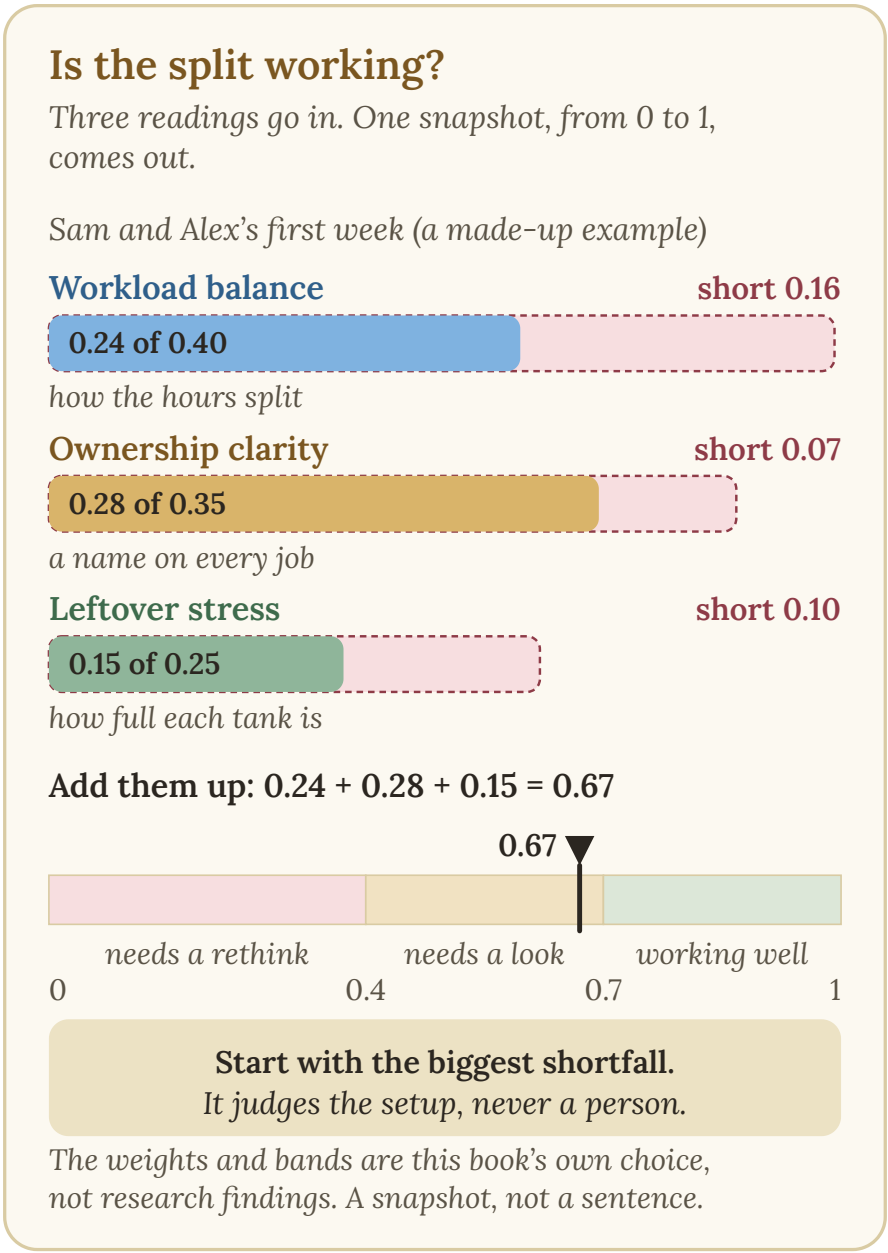


FIGURE 3 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1. One person doing everything scores 0. It doesn't matter which person is doing more. If you agreed an uneven split that suits you (say, one of you works longer hours outside the home), compare against that split instead.

For example: Three partners log 30 hours of home jobs: 15, 9 and 6. An even share is 10 each.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not keeping score of you. I just want us both to see the hours."

TRY THIS:
Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes.

Three or more of you? Compare each person's share with an even share (100 ÷ number of people), or with a split you agreed. The Lemonade Stand (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), a free page where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

The Lemonade Stand: quick look

Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name	Their name
Wren	*Josh*

Person 3
Mei

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: The Lemonade Stand quick look
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names: the owner, who does the job start to finish, and a backstop, who notices if it slipped and gently checks in (never a supervisor). It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner, then divide by all the jobs on the list. (The backstop is a good habit on top, but the count only needs the owner.) Leave jobs nobody owns on the list. They are the ones that matter most.

A *decision* you make together, like which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)". It counts as owned, because a decision needs both voices. A *job* that needs doing gets one name.

For example: Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his prescription, so each thought the other had ordered it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn't fall between us?"

TRY THIS:
Find one job with no name, and give it an owner and a backstop today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES
A job without a name tends to land on whoever notices first. Write one owner next to each job, and the guessing stops.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying). A higher score means more stress.

Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your scores. But if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the score looks fine. A setup that only works when you're both well rested isn't one that can last, so more stress lowers the result.

For example: A grandmother raising two grandchildren scores 0.70. Her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. Her 0.70 is the headline.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "My tank is high this week. Can we plan around that, not around the average?"

TRY THIS:
Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other's.

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

0.70 or above: *working well*, the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70: *needs a look*, something is drifting, often who owns what. Below 0.40: *needs a rethink, together*. (The result is called the setup score. It looks like a probability, but it isn't one. It's a simple weighted sum.)

A **weighted sum** means each part counts for a set share: the hours count most, then the owners, then stress.

For example: Two friends who run a café score 0.55. Nothing is broken, but something is drifting.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "This number is about our setup, not about us."

TRY THIS:
Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Is the setup working for everyone?

Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the Lemonade Stand: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. In the middle band that is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. Once you've both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add.

For example: Separated parents score 0.62. Their biggest gap: nobody owns school forms. They fix only that.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

TRY THIS:
Choose one small change, not five.

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

For example: One partner sees 0.35: "So I'm the problem." The other: "No. The bathroom has no owner, and you work nights."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Whatever this shows, I'm on your side."

TRY THIS:
Before you start, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back towards your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs and two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows. The other has 18. Nobody says anything for a moment. Then one of you says, "I honestly didn't know about half of these."

Words this chapter uses

- **Log:** a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took.
- **Owner:** the person who does a job from start to finish, including remembering it.
- **Backstop:** the person who notices if a job slipped and gently checks in. A helper, never a boss.
- **Stress tank:** how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life.
- **Setup:** the way you share the work right now. It can always be changed.
- **Setup score:** one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. It describes the setup, never a person.

Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing the soap is running low are all work, even though nobody sees them happen. Put them in your log.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'd like to add the thinking jobs to our list, like remembering and planning. They take time too."

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** See your own share honestly, from what you wrote down rather than from memory. See the way you share work as a setup

you can redesign, not a flaw in you.

- **Between you and others:** Put both people's numbers on one page, and read the result as a note about the setup, never a verdict on a person. Clear owners leave less room for blame.

On your own: is your own load working?

This chapter asks whether a shared setup can last. You can ask the same about your own week: are you spending more energy than comes back in?

- Add up what you carry: jobs, people and worries.
- Set it beside what refills you: rest, help, and people who give back.
- If it runs in the red, change your side: drop, delay, ask or say no kindly. A limit is a statement about supply, not about your worth.

For example: After a breakup, Leanne has her kids every other week, and fills the quiet weeks with favours for friends. Writing it down showed her she never rests. More in On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

TRY THIS:
Tonight, write three things that drained you this week and one thing that refilled you.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: matching energy (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface or the About page). The first few:

- **Finance** (See the whole load): Like a small shop asking whether it can keep paying its bills, month after month. The chapter reads the setup that way, never as a verdict on the people.
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): Ownership clarity: one owner per job, borrowed from project work, and the maker-and-checker habit from internal controls. Every regular job gets a person who does it and a backstop who notices if it slipped.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): Leftover stress: a quick self-rating of the stress you're already carrying. It borrows the idea that stress builds up in the body, but it doesn't measure your body.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): Limited capacity and the safety margin.

Two fields, one idea: Business + Economics. Unowned work falls to whoever notices first, every time. That's what turns a fixable imbalance into a repeating one, so the check counts owners, not just the hours.

In real life

- **Partners:** After a new baby arrives, the hours tip heavily one way without anyone deciding it. The check can show it before

resentment builds.

- **Family:** Two siblings share care for a parent. One lives nearby and does most of the visits. Writing down the hours helps them rebalance in other ways, like paperwork and phone calls.
- **Roommates:** Everyone agrees cleaning matters, but nobody owns the bathroom. The ownership score shows the gap straight away.
- **Coworkers:** Two people share one role. The same three questions still work: how the hours split, who owns what, and how stretched each person is.
- **Two dads:** With no old script for who does what, nothing was decided. One of them quietly took on all the school messages.
- **More than two partners:** In a home of three or more, "someone will do it" often means nobody does. Owners matter even more. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Foster and kinship carers:** Meetings, forms and contact visits are real work. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).
- **Shift workers:** Hours can look even while sleep is not. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).
- **When one of you is ill:** Share by energy, and agree an uneven split on purpose. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).
- **Dorm roommates:** A room agreement with names next to jobs settles most of it. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think the way we split things worked before, and life changed. Can we look at it again together?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests
Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning
Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing
Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms
Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems
Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

Common mix-ups

- **"A low number means the relationship is failing."** It only means the current setup needs changing. Setups change all the time.
- **"A high number means nobody can complain."** A good score never silences anyone. If something feels wrong, say so.
- **"We can just guess the numbers."** A guessed number is really just a feeling with a decimal point. Use your written logs.
- **"Taking unowned jobs off the list will help."** It raises the number and changes nothing at home.
- **"One of us can fill it in for both."** Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank.
- **"Fair means exactly 50/50."** Fair is what you both agree to, with eyes open. An uneven split you chose together can be fair. Chapter IV covers the kinds of fair.
- **"The backstop checks up on the owner."** No. The backstop only notices if something slipped, and asks kindly. It is help, not a check on someone.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs: the nursery bag, the jabs, the party invites, the next size of clothes, the night wakings. That's why the mental load (see the Preface (page 18)) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it.

- **Log the kid jobs too,** with the thinking time. Nights count.
- **Hand over whole jobs, not tasks:** the clothes and sizes, the nursery bag, the GP and jabs. The new owner does the noticing too, in their own way.

- **Baby on the way?** Write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights, and agree to look again at six weeks, three months, and before either of you goes back to work.
- **In the first weeks, share by energy, not hours.** Whoever was up in the night gets the rest; the other takes the morning.

For example (made up): Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, 3, and Poppy, 8 months. Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes come out nearly even, but Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They don't move minutes. They move one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
12 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	75	*Noticed and handled*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Fri	*Remember the nursery photo money and form*	*Hollie*	10	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	60	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big food shop and nappies*	*Both*	80	*Asked for*
Sun	*Washing for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	50	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	20	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare rota*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week and score your own tank. Then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers.

For example: A dad noticed he spent five hours a week driving his teenage son around. He just said so, and they agreed a bus pass for two days a week. See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I tried writing down my week, just for me. Can I show you one thing I noticed?"

TRY THIS:

Share one finding, not the whole list. Then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at home?

More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

TRY THIS:

Each of you logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), first. The number only means something if you each wrote your own.

Next, fill in the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet.

Then each of you scores how full your own stress tank is in How much are you carrying? on the same day.

Put the three numbers into the calculator. Look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together, and check again in a month.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Look at the month, not last night.** Use what you both wrote down, not memory.
- ✓ **Three things go in:** balance (how the hours split), ownership (does each job have a name?) and stress (how full each tank is).
- ✓ **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- ✓ **It judges the setup, never a person.** It's where a talk starts, not how one ends.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees
The unseen work the check counts page 7

Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress input, explained page 51

Book 4 · Habits and change
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes Understanding people

Chapter 6 · Helping others well
When one person carries the care page 121

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2-in-depth

3

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 3 · ONLINE: PART TWO · CHAPTER III

Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: reading your own tank
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
16. If only one of you wants to try this
17. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **A full tank overflows.** Stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute,** and say the band out loud instead of making others guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles,** and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means "later," not "never":** pause, name a time, and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

They ask, perfectly pleasantly, whether you remembered to call the dentist. Your reaction is much bigger than the question deserved, and you can hear it happening while it happens.

01

A full tank overflows.

If you're already tired, stretched or stressed from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction. That's human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you've both calmed down.

For example: A nurse gets home after a night shift. Her housemate asks, "Did you see my message?" She snaps. It wasn't the message. It was twelve hours on her feet.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I'm running on empty."

TRY THIS:

Notice one moment this week when your reaction was bigger than its cause.

02

Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself: how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of me, and how much did I bring in with me? "I'm upset about the dishes" and "I'm exhausted, and the dishes are what I noticed" are different problems.

Some of what we bring in is much older: an understanding from growing up, like "whoever notices the mess has to clean it." If a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens came

from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) helps you find where it started.

For example: A teenager has a hard day at school, comes home, and explodes because a brother took the phone charger. The charger is the last drop, not the whole tank.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes."

TRY THIS:
Before you react, ask: "How much of this is from earlier?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES
Before a hard talk, check how full your own tank is. Five quick questions, about two minutes, and you'll know whether now is the time.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

03

Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is. A higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4: sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels, and time pressure today. Add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is low. From 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate. 0.60 or more is high. If it has been high for a long time, it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it.

For example: A man caring for his wife after surgery scores 0.65 three days in a row. That tells him he needs help, not more effort.

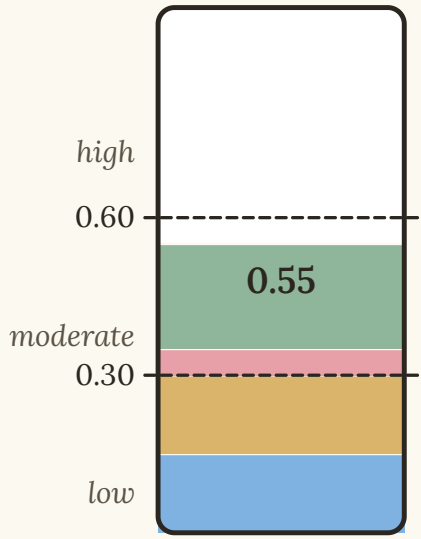
WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I checked my tank. I'm in the high band today."

TRY THIS:

Score yourself tomorrow morning, before you look at your phone.

How full is your stress tank?

Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.



Sam today

Time pressure today	4
Body: hungry, unwell, in pain	0
Unresolved conflict	1
Workload elsewhere	3
Sleep debt	3
11 ÷ 20	= 0.55

Moderate: say it before a hard talk.
"Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today."

Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.

FIGURE 4 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. Made-up example; the items and bands are this book's.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

How much are you carrying?
Rosa, who shares her mum's care with her brother

How much are you carrying?

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name
Rosa

Date
7 October 2026

The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR LOAD SCORE

Your load today
High load (13 out of 20 points)

What to do
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

If it can't wait
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

Filled most by
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

Load score
0.65 out of 1.00

Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
Mum's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Higher means more load. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02)

04

Three everyday states.

Calm and connected. Revved up. Running on empty. Knowing which one you're in tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/

quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. These labels come from polyvagal theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists. Here they are only everyday words, not a medical model.

For example: In a long-distance couple, one partner takes the video call at midnight his time. He is often running on empty. They move the hard talks to weekend mornings.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm revved up right now. Can we talk after a walk?"

> TRY THIS:
> Find one body clue for each state, like a tight jaw for "revved up."

05

There are seven angles on the same moment.

Tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate, and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure the other sees what they see. The See it from their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter) page (the Perspective Shifter), built on these seven angles, helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask instead of guesses.

For example: Planning the holidays, one parent sees it from family habit ("We always go to my mum's"). The other sees it from fairness ("We went to yours last year").

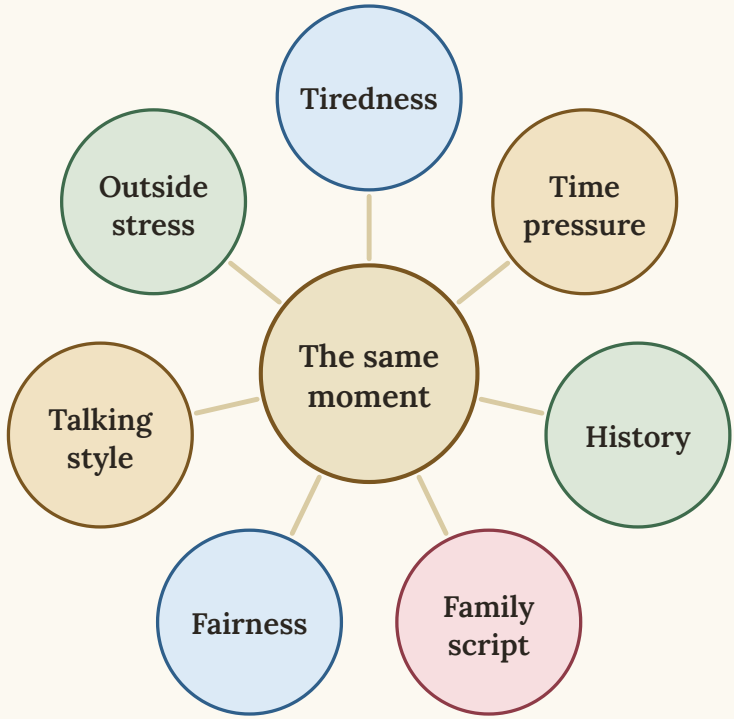
> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Which angle are you seeing this from?"

TRY THIS:

Guess which of the seven angles you look from most often.

Seven angles on the same moment

Which one are you looking from right now?



An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.
Name your own. Ask about theirs.

Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Perspective Shifter page uses the same seven.

FIGURE 5 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

See it from their side (the Perspective Shifter)

Hana, about her friend Lou

See it from their side

1. What happened?

I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe".

2. Who are they to you?

Partner · Family · Roommate · *Friend* · Coworker · Co-parent · My teen or child · Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected · Revved up · *Running on empty* · I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day · *Little sleep* · Rushed or late · Money worries · *Caring for someone* · Not feeling their best · A noisy or crowded place · Other people were there · *It was a text or message* · It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot · They take words literally · *They need time to process* · They think out loud · They're very direct · They hint rather than say · They like a plan · Noise, light or crowds get to them · Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before · They grew up with it done differently · *It's a sore topic for them* · They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload | *a message, call or news you didn't see* | something they had already planned or done | how it looked from where they stood | a promise someone else made them | how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done | *the reason behind your timing* | what you actually meant | how tired or stretched you were | the part already done | a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

each other's tone, in writing | what was going on in the other's head | what would happen next | what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether, for you, you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. These are

possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.

Fill in your own: See it from their side
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter)

06

Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing. The question isn't "Who's right?" but "Which angle are you seeing this from?"

For example: Two adult brothers argue about their late mother's house. One sees memories. The other sees bills. Both are real.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

TRY THIS:
Say the other person's view back to them before you give yours.

07

Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your stress tank is and which angle you're seeing things from. It works best before you start, not in the middle.

For example: Two coworkers start a tense meeting with one sentence each about their tank and angle. The meeting is shorter, and calmer.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Before we start: I'm about half full today, and I'm seeing this from the time angle."

TRY THIS:

Use that one-line opener once this week.



TIDBIT

Tidbit's tip: say your number out loud, like "I'm a seven today." It's quick, and nobody has to guess!

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

08

A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause, never a way out of the talk. Say when you'll come back, and the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) can help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, if you still feel hot, take another round. Still 0.60 or more after two rounds? That's okay. Pick a new time, and say when.

For example: A dad and his 14-year-old get heated about phone time. He says, "I'm too wound up. Let's talk at seven." At seven, he knocks on her door.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need a break. I'll come back at seven. I promise."

TRY THIS:

Whenever you pause, name the time you'll come back.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

MONDAY MORNING

You both look at the same pile of mail on the table. One of you sees a to-do list. The other sees proof that nobody else ever opens the mail. Same pile. Two different pictures.

Words this chapter uses

- **Stress tank:** how much stress you are already carrying, before this moment even starts.
- **Leftover stress:** the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day.
- **This-moment stress:** the part caused by what is in front of you right now.
- **Angle:** the point of view you are seeing a moment from, like tiredness or fairness.
- **How much are you carrying?:** a free one-minute worksheet that scores your stress tank.
- **Calm-Down Kit:** a short plan for stepping away well and coming back.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Know how full your stress tank is, and which angle you are seeing from, before you judge a moment.

- **Between you and others:** Choose the timing, pause and come back. Your state shapes how the other person's words land, so say it out loud, and ask which angle they are seeing from.

On your own: reading your own tank

A full tank makes small things feel big. On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your battery before you react.

- Check your battery for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern.
- Before a hard moment, ask yourself how much of this is leftover from earlier.
- Decide on a calm day what settles you, so it's ready when you need it.

For example: Living alone after a breakup, Bryony noticed she snapped at her sister every Monday. Her mornings showed why: Sunday nights were her worst sleep of the week. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Mondays are hard for me. Can we talk on Tuesday instead?"

> IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:
> Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 4: plan what settles you · Part One: what settles you (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on staying calm (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-calm)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 7) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): The autonomic nervous system runs stress and rest without asking you.
- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): Leftover stress versus this-moment stress, family scripts and communication styles: the angles you see a moment from.
- **Philosophy** (Tune how you send and receive): Two true views of the same thing (the Blind Men and the Elephant), and the Second Arrow: what happened is the first arrow, and the story we add is the second.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second.
- **Behavioural science** (Read your state first): Say it before the talk, with a named time to come back. Practise small routines on calm days.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): A tank that's nearly full has no room to spare.

Two fields, one idea: Philosophy + Neurobiology. What happened is the first arrow. The story we add is the second. A full stress tank makes that second arrow easier to add, so say your tank and your angle out loud first.

In real life

- **Partners:** After a bad night's sleep, "What's for dinner?" sounds like "Why haven't you taken care of dinner?"
- **Family:** A parent asks about your job search. They see it from the angle of worry. You see it from the angle of an old pattern: "They've never trusted me."

- **Roommates:** Loud music at 11pm. One roommate sees it as a fairness issue. The other grew up in a noisy house and honestly didn't notice.
- **Coworkers:** A late-night email. The sender was clearing their inbox. The reader, who is already stretched, feels pressure to answer right away.
- **Two mums:** One comes home from a hard shift to a toddler's meltdown. Her "I can't do this" is about the shift, not the toddler or her wife. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).
- **More than two partners:** In a home of three, a check-in round where everyone says their tank first stops two people guessing about the third. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Foster and kinship carers:** After a contact visit, a child's tank is often full. A slammed door that evening may be about the visit, not the carer. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).
- **A child with ADHD:** The end of a school day can leave the tank brim full. Big talks go better after food and rest. See When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids).
- **Two faiths:** A festival can mean joy to one partner and pressure to the other. Same day, two angles. See Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).
- **Coming out:** A parent's silence may be shock, not rejection. Your own tank may be full for weeks afterwards. See Coming out (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think my tank was full before you walked in. Can we start again?"

Common mix-ups

- **"A big reaction means it was a big deal."** Sometimes. Often it means the tank was already full.
- **"A high score is an excuse."** It's a note to come back later, not a pass to skip the talk.
- **"I can tell how full their tank is."** Only they can say. Each person scores only themselves.
- **"Pausing is the same as the silent treatment."** A pause has a time to come back. The silent treatment doesn't. Always say when.
- **"If we see it differently, one of us is wrong."** You may just be standing at different angles.
- **"Naming my angle means giving up my point."** It just helps the other person see where your point is coming from.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I don't think you're wrong. I think we're standing in different places. Can we swap for a minute?"

Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank. Being quiet, clingy or cross for a few hours after a handover is common. It usually isn't a sign that something is wrong at the other home.

- **Landing time:** a snack, something familiar, and no questions about the other home for the first hour.
- **The child is never the messenger.** Adult news goes adult to adult.
- **Money:** follow any formal arrangement. Split the extras by a ratio you agree, keep one list, and settle up once a month.

- **With an ex, share the band, not the story:** "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?" Your private life stays yours.
- **An ex who won't cooperate but isn't dangerous:** try parallel parenting. Written messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school, and your own list for your own home.
- **New partners:** the parent stays the owner of anything involving the other home. A step-parent starts as a friendly adult, not the one who tells the children off.

For example (made up): Harriet gives Freya, 8, and Arlo, 5, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's. She stopped asking "What happened at Dad's?" at the door. Sunday evenings got calmer.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE):
> "Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on 6 November and costs £24. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If you are afraid of your ex, a shared plan isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this on your own side. Check your own tank. Name your own angle. Pause and come back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help. Often, when one person starts saying it out loud, the other starts to as well.

For example: A daughter visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash over his health. She starts each visit with "I'm a bit tired today, so if I go quiet, it's not you." He never scores anything. The visits still get calmer.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I've been trying something. I just tell you how my day was before we talk about the hard stuff."

TRY THIS:

Start your next hard talk with one sentence about your own tank, and nothing about theirs.

A note on safety: A full tank explains a reaction. It never excuses shouting, threats or hurting anyone. If someone's "stress" often turns into fear for you, that isn't a tank problem. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If sharing how you feel ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

More for your situation

Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

TRY THIS:

Before your next hard conversation, check how full your own tank is.

Score the five things in How much are you carrying?, add them up and divide by 20.

Then say one sentence out loud, such as: "My stress tank's about half full today, and I'm mostly seeing this from the time-pressure angle."

If either of you scores 0.60 or more, put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. Agree on a time to come back, and keep it.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A full tank overflows.** Stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- ✓ **Check your tank in a minute,** and say the band out loud instead of making others guess.
- ✓ **Two people can see one moment from different angles,** and both views can be true.
- ✓ **A full tank means "later," not "never":** pause, name a time, and come back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system
The ladder, flooding and rest — Together

Book 2 · How we see each other
The angles and stories behind a reaction — Together

Book 2 · Anger
What to do in the hot minutes — Together

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your own weather first — Self-discovery

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3-in-depth

4

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE: PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. Each idea in everyday life
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your own kind of fair
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Money between you
16. A couple and a housemate
17. More for your situation
18. A note on safety

IN SHORT:

- **There are two kinds of fair:** by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?). Agree which one you're using.
- **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.** Covering for someone is kind when you say it out loud.
- **Let a comment land before you react:** notice it, name it, then decide what to say.

- **Keep the two questions apart:** "Was the job done?" is about a fact; "Did that comment hurt?" is about a feeling.

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

One of you counts hours. The other counts who noticed the job needed doing. You're both counting honestly, in two different currencies, and then arguing about the exchange rate.

01

There are two kinds of fair.

"Did everything get done?" and "Did each of us do what we said we'd do?" Both are reasonable. Friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realising.

02

Fair by results.

This kind judges by outcomes: did the right things get done, by whoever had the time or energy? It's flexible and easy-going. Done carefully, it counts the cost to whoever covered, but done carelessly, it can hide who is always stepping in.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

The Lemonade Stand: the Money tab

Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes

Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
£ *(pounds)*

Bill	Grace paid (£)	Ruth paid (£)	How it's shared
Rent	1,100	700	*Shared, split*

Bill	Grace paid (£)	Ruth paid (£)	How it's shared
Power and water	160	0	*Shared, split*
Internet and phones	0	90	*Shared, split*
Groceries	300	250	*Shared, split*

	Grace brings in (£)	Ruth brings in (£)	How it's shared
Pay	4,200	2,800	*Money coming in*

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace £1,560; Ruth £1,040.

Coming in: £7,000 (Grace £4,200, Ruth £2,800). After shared bills: £4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in £260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Money is a fair topic only where nobody controls the other's money.

Fill in your own: The Lemonade Stand (Money tab)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

03

Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It's clear and steady, but it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way.

04

Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job, start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop who notices if it slipped and gently checks in, never a supervisor. (It can be the same person.) If it's your job, the question is whether you did it, not whether someone else quietly covered for you. That protects the person who keeps filling the gaps.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

One owner per job

Dee and Mark, foster carers

One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A
Dee

Person B
Mark

Date of this list
4 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Dee works three days; Mark works full time

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Social worker visits	*Monthly*	1.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark joins by video when he can*
Reviews and meetings	*As needed*	2	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones*

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Daily log and placement paperwork	*Daily*	0.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark writes it on Dee's work days*
Contact visits and calls with their family	*Weekly*	1.5	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Saturday mornings*
School liaison (designated teacher, plans)	*As needed*	1	*Dee*		
Being there after contact	*As needed*	1	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Quiet tea, no questions*
Health and therapy appointments	*As needed*	1.5	*Dee*		
Training and support group	*Monthly*	2	*Mark*		*Mark's turn this term*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs are spread
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time". Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
Dee and Mark

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. "Being there

after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely. Just mention it, so the help is seen: "I put the bins out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency)).



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: covering for someone is kind. Say it out loud, gently, and ask for what you'd like next time, so it doesn't turn into quiet resentment.

TOOL **Turn a complaint into a request** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

06

Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say "Give me a second." The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically, in a fraction of a second. This book's pause is different: a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether it needs an answer now, later or not at all.

07

Notice, name, decide.

Notice it landed hard. Name it kindly: "That hit harder than you probably meant." Then, once you've settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

Say it so it lands

Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi

Say it so it lands

Your name

Carla

Date

8 October 2026

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction

Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)

The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4.

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)

I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)

Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(Yes) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (Not sure)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(Yes) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

Their words A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ways to say it
Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Suggestions
Your own load is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09)

08

Keep the two questions apart.

"Was the job done?" is a question about a fact. "Did that comment hurt?" is a question about a feeling. Both matter. Answer them one at a time, not in the same argument.

Each idea in everyday life

The sections above say what each idea means. Here each one gets a real-life example, words you could say, and one small step.

1. Two kinds of fair

For example: Nisha and Kezia share a dorm room. Nisha thinks it's fair if the room is tidy by Friday, whoever tidies. Kezia thinks it's

fair if each keeps their own half clean. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

TRY THIS:

Each finish this sentence, then compare: "To me, a fair week is one where…"

Two kinds of fair

Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when you use different ones without saying so.

Fair by results

Asks: Did it all get done?

Guards: Will the home keep running?

Good: flexible. Watch: it can hide who always steps in.

- Bins ✓
- Dentist ✓
- Forms ✓

Fair by promises

Asks: Did each of us do what we agreed?

Guards: Can I rely on you?

Good: clear. Watch: it can feel rigid in a hard week.

- Bins · Sam ✓
- Dentist · Maya ✗
- Forms · Lin ✓

The agreement: look to the owner

Bins · owner: Sam

second name: Alex, who notices and asks once

Once a job has a named owner, judge it by whether the owner did their part (swapping or asking ahead counts), not by whether someone quietly covered. Made-up examples.

FIGURE 6 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable; trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

2. Fair by results

For example: A grandmother is raising her grandchildren. Her grown-up son helps "wherever it's needed" when he's home. The house runs, but she is always the one who notices what's needed. See Kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I like that we're flexible. Can we also check who ends up stepping in most?"

TRY THIS:
For one week, mark every job you picked up that wasn't planned.

3. Fair by promises

For example: Two business partners run a café. One owns the ordering, the other the staff rota. When the rota is late, they ask the rota owner, not "the team."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take the bins?"

TRY THIS:
Name one job that is "sort of everyone's." Agree who owns it for a month.

4. Look to the owner

For example: In a stepfamily, the 13-year-old owns feeding the dog, and his stepmum is the second name. At 7pm the bowl is empty. She says, "Dog's dinner?" once. She doesn't do it for him, and she doesn't lecture.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"This one's yours, start to finish. I'll only remind you if it slips."

TRY THIS:

Pick one job that causes friction and write two names next to it.

5. Covering out loud

For example: Two grown-up sisters take turns driving their dad to appointments. When one covers, she texts: "I took Dad Thursday since you had the late shift. Just so you know."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Thank you for covering that. How was it for you?"

TRY THIS:

Next time you cover a job, mention it in one plain sentence, the same day.

6. Let a comment land

For example: A nurse comes home from a night shift. Her husband says, "Oh, you're up." She hears "at last," but says, "Give me a second, I'm very tired." He meant he was glad to see her. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"That landed hard. Let me think before I answer."

TRY THIS:

Agree on your "give me a second" phrase today, on a calm day.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a comment stings, give it a minute to land before you answer. This workpaper is a short check for your reply.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

7. Notice, name, decide

For example: A teenager tells her dad, "You never listen." He feels his chest tighten (notice). He says, "That stings, and I want to hear you properly" (name). He decides it needs a real talk tomorrow (decide). See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I want to answer that, just not this minute. Can we talk at eight?"

TRY THIS:

Put the three words somewhere you'll see them, like the fridge.

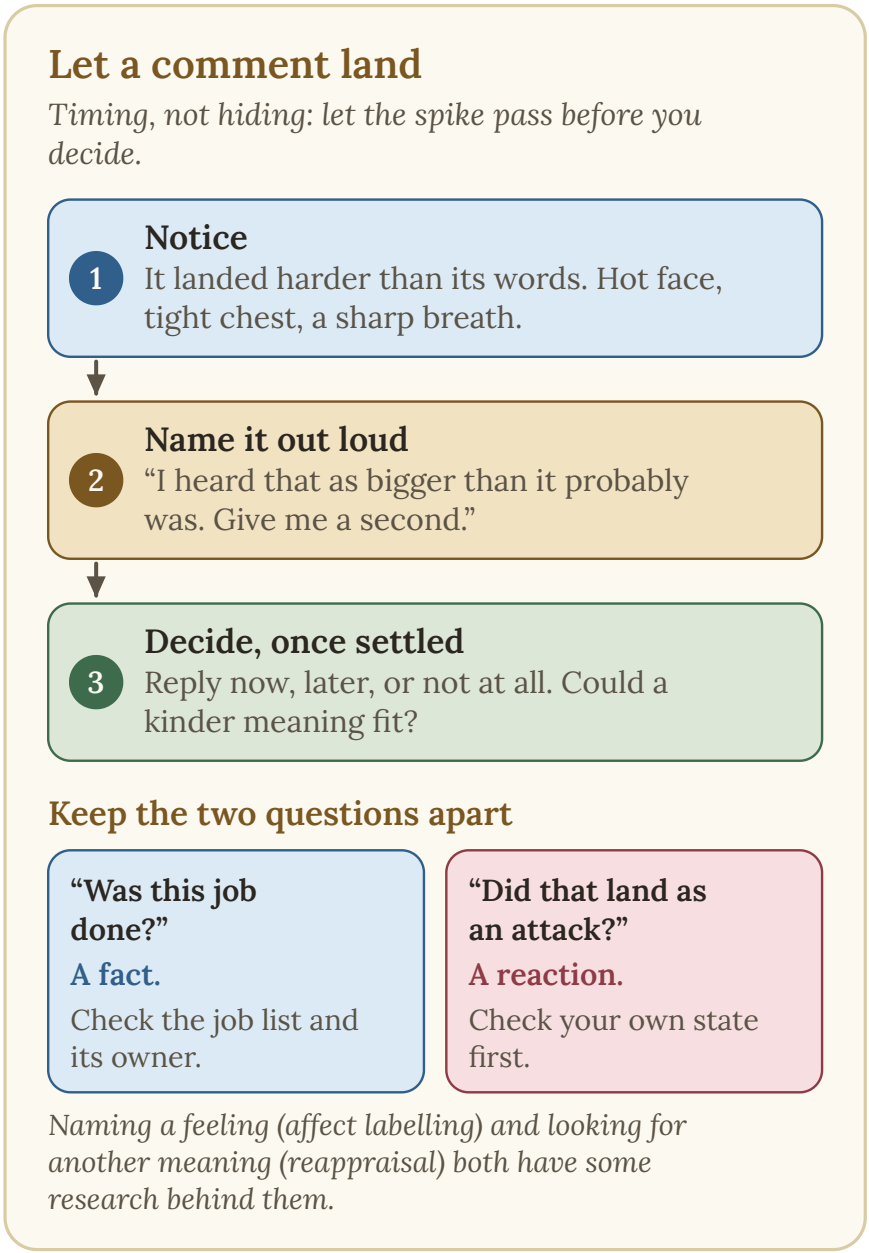


FIGURE 7 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

8. Keep the two questions apart

For example: Separated parents share the kids across two homes. The bag came back without the school shoes (a fact). The text about it felt cold (a feeling). They sort the shoes first. See Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we sort the shoes first, and come back to how that text felt?"

TRY THIS:

When a talk tangles, ask, "Fact or feeling?" and finish one first.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the bins, but Alex works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken it out three weeks running. At the catch-up, Sam mentions it. Alex says Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month: Sam takes the bins, and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order. They'll settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter V (page 97).

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, a little flatly. It was meant as a thank-you. It sounded like a criticism. Before you know it, you've replied to the criticism, and now there really is one.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Notice which kind of fair comes naturally to you, and notice the quiet habit of covering for others without saying so. When a comment stings, check your own state before you answer.
- **Between you and others:** Give each job one clear owner instead of blaming. Watch how unowned jobs slide towards one person, and keep things steady by mentioning help out loud and saying thank you.

On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what fair means to you, and which jobs are truly yours.

- Write down what fair means to you, in one sentence.
- List the jobs you own, and the ones you picked up without ever agreeing.
- Practise letting a comment land before you answer, then reply with a fact, a feeling and an ask.

For example: Olu lives alone and has his kids every other weekend. His line: "Fair is not doing their jobs just because I miss them." See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

TRY THIS:

Pick one job you took on without agreeing. Keep it on purpose, or raise it on a calm day.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 5: find words for what you feel (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: where your sense of fair came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 7) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)).

- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): Two old ideas behind fairness: judging by outcomes (consequentialist) and judging by promises (deontological).
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): Look to the owner.
- **Economics** (Notice the quiet incentives): Two people keeping score in two currencies, then arguing about the exchange rate.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): How the brain turns down sounds and sensations, borrowed loosely. In the brain it is automatic and takes a fraction of a second; here it's a few seconds you choose to take.
- **Aromatherapy** (Read your state first): For some people, a familiar scent or a calmer room is a quick cue to slow down. Where and when you talk is part of the method.
- **Psychology** (Notice the quiet incentives): Why a flat "thanks" can be heard as sarcasm, and why covering turns sour only when it's

silent.

Two fields, one idea: Philosophy + Business. People can mean two different things by "fair." A job list with one owner per job makes it simple: check the job, not the person.

In real life

- **Partners:** One counts hours spent cleaning. The other counts all the planning that happened before anyone picked up a cloth. Both are real work, so put the planning on the list too, in minutes.
- **Parents:** Older kids can own age-sized jobs too, like feeding the cat or packing their own lunch. Put their name on the list, with a parent as the second name.
- **Family:** One sibling visits a parent every week. Another pays for extra help. Each thinks they're doing their share, in a different currency.
- **Roommates:** One wants a fixed schedule. The other prefers "whoever's free does it." Neither is lazy. They just use different kinds of fair.
- **Coworkers:** One person quietly fixes everyone else's slides before the meeting. Because it always gets done, nobody knows it was ever a problem.
- **More than two partners:** In a home with three adults, the one who works from home is always the one who "can." See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Different hours:** Someone who works nights sleeps in the day. Being home isn't being free. See Different hours.
- **When one is ill:** Share by energy, not hours, with a backup agreed for low days. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

- **Friends:** One friend always hosts, and nobody thanks them anymore. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I think we're counting in different ways. Can we put both on the list?"

TRY THIS:
Read the example closest to your home to the other person, and ask, "Does this sound like us?"

Common mix-ups

- **"If it got done, there's no problem."** Someone may be paying for that in time and energy.
- **"Holding the owner to it is being strict."** It's just keeping the agreement you both made. That's kinder than quiet resentment.
- **"Letting a comment land means ignoring it."** It's about timing, not about swallowing your feelings.
- **"'Give me a second' is rude."** It's a way of taking the other person seriously enough to answer well.
- **"One kind of fair is the right one."** Both are reasonable. What matters is agreeing which one you'll use.
- **"The owner is the boss of that job."** The owner does the job. They don't direct everyone else, and the second name isn't a supervisor.
- **"I covered for months, so now I can bring it all up."** A long list lands as a bill. Mention covering as it happens.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't think either of us is wrong. I think we've been using different rulers."

Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Three common ways to share it:

- **All shared:** both incomes go into one pot.
- **Separate:** each keeps their own money and pays agreed bills, often half each. That's fair by promises: the same rule for both.
- **Proportional:** each puts into a shared pot in line with what they earn, and keeps the rest. That's fair by results: each is left with a similar share.

Many couples mix them: a joint account for bills and food, and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories (how money worked at home when you were growing up), then the numbers, then a "talk first" amount for big buys that applies to both of you. A limit you both chose and both keep is care, not control.

For example (made up): Niamh takes home £2,600 a month and Tariq £1,900. Rent and bills will be £1,500. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay: £870 and £630.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?" "Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

A couple and a housemate

A couple sharing a home with a housemate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. Keep two lists: **house jobs** for all three of you (bins, bathroom, bills, the landlord), and **couple jobs** just for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, not in bed the night before. Hear the housemate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms, and never ask them to be the referee.

For example (made up): Ollie and Hamza share a flat with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room (the couple has the bigger one) and the bills by person. All three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "That's a house question. Let's decide it when Bex is here."

More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- Friends · More than two partners · Sharing a room · Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own

TRY THIS:

Agree on what counts as fair on a calm, easy day, not in the middle of a disagreement.

Start by each saying which kind of fair comes more naturally to you: results or promises.

Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list: the person who does it. Add a second name, someone who notices if it slips. It can be the same person.

Finally, agree on a short phrase for when something lands hard, like "Give me a second." Agree that the other person will wait, and that the person who asked for a second will come back to it.

A note on safety

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about what's fair ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. Rules one person sets for the other, with checking, punishment or money held back, are control, and that is not your fault. See normal limits and control.

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH SOMEONE YOU TRUST:

"Things at home don't feel fair, and I'm scared to bring it up. Can I talk it through with you?"

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **There are two kinds of fair:** by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?). Agree which one you're using.
- ✓ **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.** Covering for someone is kind when you say it out loud.
- ✓ **Let a comment land before you react:** notice it, name it, then decide what to say.
- ✓ **Keep the two questions apart:** "Was the job done?" is about a fact; "Did that comment hurt?" is about a feeling.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2 · Healing after hurt — Together
Repair and apologies that land

Book 2 · How communication works — Together
Letting words land before you reply

Book 1 · Values, meaning and a good life — Self-discovery
Fairness as a value you choose together

Book 4 · Groups, influence and culture — Understanding people
How a group's norms decide what feels fair

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4-in-depth

5

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 5 · ONLINE: PART TWO · CHAPTER V

The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. Each idea in everyday life
11. Inside you, and between you
12. In real life
13. Common mix-ups
14. Starting out: before you move in
15. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
16. More for your situation
17. On your own: a monthly look at yourself
18. The fields behind this chapter

IN SHORT:

- **Weekly check-ins miss patterns.** Once a month, look back over four weeks of notes and your job list.
- **Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.** Anything with two or more gets sorted.
- **A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.** Fix the setup, not the person.

- **Keep it short and kind**, and look back even in the quiet months.

THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

The bins again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth about Tuesday. Or you could notice that Tuesday has now happened three times, and ask what it is about Tuesdays.

01

Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and it's easiest to see when you look at the whole month. The "audit" here is a careful, friendly look back, more like a self-check than an inspection.

02

You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01) (a few lines a week is enough) and your job list from One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). That's all. Twenty minutes is usually enough. If either of your stress tanks is high that day (0.60 or more on How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying)), move it a day or two.

03

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job "slipped" if it was noticed but not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗. Three or four in a month is a real pattern, not just bad luck.

04

A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

It gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job, start to finish. The fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
Laura

Person B
Dan

Date of this list
1 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Pack the handoff bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it*
Send medicine and chargers with the bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card*

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
School forms and permission slips	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	
Reply to school emails and apps	*Weekly*	*Dan*		*Dan reads them Sunday night*
Kids' doctor and dentist visits	*As needed*	*Dan*		*Dan books; tells Laura the date*
Homework help (Laura's weeks)	*Daily*	*Laura*		
Homework help (Dan's weeks)	*Daily*	*Dan*		
Activities and sign-ups	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	*Swimming and Cubs*
Buy clothes as they outgrow them	*As needed*	*Laura*		*Receipts in the shared folder*
Big decisions (school, health, new activities)	*As needed*	*Both (decide together)*		*A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs sit across the homes
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5". Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. If one parent is afraid of the other, a shared list isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? on this site.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

No clear owner: update the job list. An owner who can't keep up: have a kind, honest talk. A short-term cause, like illness or travel: note it and move on.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

What keeps coming back?
Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home

What keeps coming back?

Person A
Ash

Person B
Robin

Person C
Jules

Month
September 2026

Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged
Cat litter	✗	✗		✗	3
Recycling out on Thursday		✗	✗		2
Book Jules's car service			✗		1
Shared calendar kept up to date	✗	✗	✗	✗	4

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

Task	Named owner on the job list?	Classification	Action
Cat litter	*No*	*Structural gap*	*Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight*
Shared calendar kept up to date	*Yes*	*Capacity issue*	*Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list*
Recycling out on Thursday	*Yes*	*One-off, no action*	*Two bank holidays moved the day*

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

Structural gaps found

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

Capacity issues found

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

One-offs

1

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked	Only noticed when missed?	One way to notice it
Keeping the calendar	*Rarely*	*Yes*	*Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date*
Topping up the cat food	*Never*	*Yes*	*A note on the fridge*

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04)

06

Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working; one month can be a normal swing. If it keeps rising, something bigger has changed, and it's worth a talk.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The look-back has its own workpaper: a month of notes, one list, and an ✗ for each week a job slipped. It makes a pattern easy to see.

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

07

Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news, and it's also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going on quiet months, and add one question: "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning?*" That is how a look-back guards against complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

08

It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before; you just don't bill for the past. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet, and what you'll try next month.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: a look-back can start with a high five. Name one thing that went well first! The weekly card has a nice way to begin.

TOOL **Weekly check-in card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

09

Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well. Talk about the job, not the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins). If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and the person who paused names a time to come back.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

This week's check-in card

Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together

Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)
Linda and Jordan

One thing that went well
Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.

One thing that felt heavy
The bathroom, again. And Mum's back was bad all week.

One small thing to try next week
Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.

Our next check-in
Sunday after dinner

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented.

Fill in your own: This week's check-in card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

Each idea in everyday life

The sections above say what each idea means. Here each one gets a real-life example, words you could say, and one small step.

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns

For example: Four flatmates. Each week the bathroom bin overflowed, and each week it looked like bad luck. Looking at the whole month showed it happened every single week.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we look at the whole month, not just this week?"

TRY THIS:

Pick a monthly date now, like the last Sunday, and put it in both calendars.

2. Four weeks of notes and one list

For example: A couple on different shifts keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones. They do the look-back on the one evening they're both off. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I'm running on empty today. Can we move the look-back to Thursday?"

TRY THIS:
Choose one place where both of you can find the weekly notes.

3. Mark an ✗ when a job slipped

For example: Two foster carers look back. The reading log was missed three weeks out of four. Three ✗ means it's a pattern, not a bad week. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"This isn't about who. It's just which jobs slipped."

TRY THIS:
Mark the ✗ in pencil, together, before anyone explains anything.

4. A repeat usually has no real owner

For example: Three partners share a home. "Whoever's free" does the grocery order, and it was late three times. Nobody owned it, so everybody assumed. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Whose name is next to this one? If nobody's, shall we pick?"

TRY THIS:
For each job with two or more ✗, check that one name is written next to it.

5. Sort each repeat

For example: Separated parents look at the missed homework folder. Was nobody sure which home signs it (no owner)? Is one parent swamped (can't keep up)? Or was it the week she had flu (a one-off)? See Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Is this a list problem, a too-much problem, or just a bad week?"

> TRY THIS:
> Write one of the three kinds next to every repeat before you decide what to do.

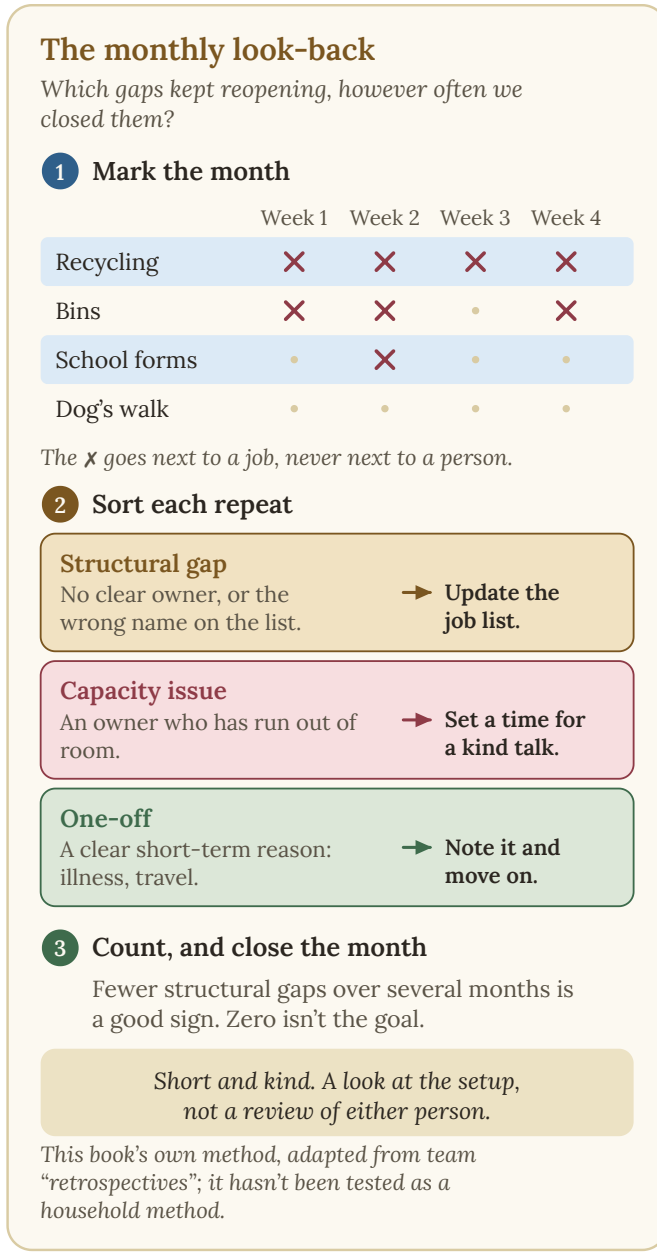


FIGURE 8 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

6. Count the gaps

For example: Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office. In March, four jobs had no clear owner. By June, one did.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Let's just write the numbers down and see how they look in three months."

> TRY THIS:
> Write this month's three numbers on the back page of your notes.

7. Look back on quiet months too

For example: The kids have left home and nothing is slipping. At the look-back, one of them says, "We don't really talk at dinner anymore." Nothing was broken. Something was drifting. See Kids grown and gone (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning?"

> TRY THIS:
> Keep the date on a quiet month, and ask just that one question.

8. Not a review of either person

For example: After a month in hospital, one partner comes home to a long list of what slipped. They thank each other for what each carried instead, and fix only next month. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I see how much you carried. Let's just set up next month."

TRY THIS:

If you notice yourself adding up past hours, stop and say one thank-you instead.

9. Short and kind

For example: A mum and two teens hold their look-back over pizza. Each says one good thing first. One gap gets a new owner. It's over in fifteen minutes. See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"This needs a proper talk. Can we do it Thursday, not now?"

TRY THIS:

Set a timer for twenty minutes, and stop when it rings.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes and twenty minutes. You go down the list. Most weeks went fine. Two jobs keep coming up. That's the whole meeting, and it's enough.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Look at your own routines as a setup you can adjust. Spot the easy defaults, like "I'll just do it," that let a gap quietly

reopen.

- **Between you and others:** Look at the month together, give repeating gaps a clear owner, and keep count so jobs don't drift back to whoever notices first.

In real life

- **Partners:** Sam and Alex's bins slipped three weeks in a row, because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After a trial swap, they make it official: Sam owns the bins, and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, so the hours stay even.
- **Family:** Three siblings keep forgetting to call their dad's landlord about repairs. It turns out nobody ever agreed who would.
- **Roommates:** The recycling overflows every other week. Everyone thought someone else was taking it down.
- **Coworkers:** Meeting notes go missing twice a month. Giving note-taking a named owner fixes it by the next month.
- **Long distance:** A couple in two cities do the look-back by video. Their repeat is "who calls first," so they give it an owner per weekday. See Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).
- **Friends:** Two friends notice their monthly dinner has been cancelled three times. Nobody owned booking it. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Grandparents and parents:** School pick-ups by grandma slipped twice, both on days she wasn't told about. The gap was the message, not grandma. See Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

Common mix-ups

- **"This is where we settle who owes what."** Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them. You only fix the setup going forward.
- **"If a job slipped, the owner failed."** The gap might be in the list, in the owner's capacity, or just a one-off week.
- **"One bad week means we should change everything."** Don't make a lasting change because of a short-term cause.
- **"We can skip the weekly checks and just do this."** The monthly look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.
- **"More gaps this month means we're failing."** One month can be a normal swing, or it can mean life changed. That's a reason to talk, not to worry.
- **"The look-back is for the person who keeps the notes."** It works best when both bring their notes, and both talk.

A note on safety: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If looking back together ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A look-back is something you both choose. If one person demands logs of the other's every hour, checks their phone without agreement, or uses the ✗ marks to punish, that is control, not a look-back, and it is not your fault. See Not safe at home? and normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).

Starting out: before you move in

New together, and about to share a home? The tools work best now, before habits set. A gentle order, about one step a week:

1. **Week 1:** each write down the rulebook from the home you grew up in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up), then swap. Be curious, not judging.
2. **Week 2:** talk about money: your money stories first, then the split (Chapter IV (page 92)).
3. **Week 3:** write your first job list, with one owner per job, thinking jobs included (One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)).
4. **Week 4:** make a pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) on a calm day.
5. **Week 5:** each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Part Three, Chapter 10 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values)).
6. **After the move:** log one ordinary week after two weeks, and do your first short look-back after four.

It isn't a test, and it isn't keeping score. It's so neither of you has to guess.

For example (made up): Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find their families meant different things by "tidy." They agree: kitchen every night, the rest on Sunday.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't want us to keep score. I just want us never to have to guess. Could we try a few small things before we move?"

Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it is about things that keep coming back:

cancelled calls, hard evenings after contact, forms. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own; some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't. For those, own the plan for the evening after.

- **The loyalty bind:** the child may love the parent who can't look after them and you. Tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them.
- **Explaining an absent parent:** short, true and kind, in words for their age, and always "it's not your fault."
- **When the parent is your own adult child** and things are hard between you: keep messages about the child short and civil, for the child's sake, and leave the door open.
- **Look after yourself:** ask for respite and join other kinship carers. In England and Wales, the charity Kinship (kinship.org.uk) can help.

For example (made up): Maureen, 63, is raising her grandson Tyler, 9. Her look-back shows his mum's Sunday call fell through three times this month. She plans those evenings (hot chocolate, his football annual) and asks her brother to take Tyler swimming on Sunday afternoons.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD:
> "Mum loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. These pages take it into one situation each. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- More than two partners · Money together · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Kids grown and gone
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month, kindly. Not a scorecard, more like a weather report.

- What filled your battery this month, and what drained it?
- Which of your limits held, and which slipped?
- Choose one small thing to keep, and one to change next month.

For example: Gillian lives on her own after a divorce. Her monthly look-back shows the same ✗ three weeks running: she skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails. She moves the emails, not the swim. See On my own.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE (TO YOURSELF):
> "Not a scorecard. Just this month's weather."

> TRY THIS:
> On the last day of this month, write three lines: one thing that filled you, one that drained you, one thing to change.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

The Individual package and your report (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Part One: a kind monthly look at yourself (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next-in-depth) · Step 1: check your battery · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 7 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 7) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Finance** (See the whole load): The month-end close: check the plan against the log, so next month starts clean.
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): The audit habit, as a friendly self-check. A job that keeps slipping usually has no real owner.
- **Economics** (Notice the quiet incentives): Past hours can't be handed back, so they aren't billed.
- **Behavioural science** (Notice the quiet incentives): Three or four slips in a month is a pattern that's easy to miss week by week.
- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): Say a pattern as a repeated fact, not a verdict.
- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): The Ship of Theseus: a ship rebuilt plank by plank is still the same ship. Your agreements can be rebuilt and still be yours.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second. A calm look-back a few days late beats a tense one on time.

Two fields, one idea: Finance + Business. Once a month, look back like an audit: which jobs kept slipping? A job that keeps slipping

usually needs an owner, not more effort.

TRY THIS:

Put a relaxed 20-minute date on the calendar, once a month.

Until then, keep your weekly Who did what notes somewhere you can both find them.

At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well this month.

End by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so over the next few months you can see if the number is falling.

That's the end of Part Two. The book goes on in Part Three: Understanding people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings), chapters on how people work, for anyone. To put Parts One and Two into practice first, try the six-week program (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01): six gentle weeks, with one chapter and one small tool each week.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Weekly check-ins miss patterns.** Once a month, look back over four weeks of notes and your job list.
- ✓ **Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.** Anything with two or more gets sorted.
- ✓ **A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.** Fix the setup, not the person.
- ✓ **Keep it short and kind,** and look back even in the quiet months.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Who you are becoming
The same kind look, on your own — Self-discovery

Book 4 · Habits and change
Why problems come back, and how habits stick — Understanding people

Chapter 2 · Is the split working?
The setup score the look-back feeds — page 27

Book 2 · Healing after hurt
Repairing what the look-back finds — Together

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 6: make it last
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5-in-depth

6

BOOK 3 · CHAPTER 6 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 12

Helping others well: support without fixing, boundaries, and not burning out

How to help someone without taking over: asking what they need, listening first, caring without drowning, keeping kind limits, what to do in a crisis, and how to keep going without burning out.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Ask what kind of help they want
2. Listening is a kind of help
3. Fixing it for them can take away their power
4. Care without drowning in their feelings
5. Your limits make your help last
6. Notice when you're running on empty
7. In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help
8. Don't wait for someone else to step in
9. Let other people help you too
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- **Listening is help.** Fixing it for someone can take away their power.
- **Your limits make your help last.** Caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.

- **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **One owner per job: sharing the care** (Part Two, Chapter IV (page 73)) works because help lasts when it is shared and named. Carers burn out when everything is "just helping" and nobody else owns a job. Big idea: *see the whole load.*
- **How much are you carrying?** (Part Two, Chapter III (page 51)) helps you notice when you are running on empty before you snap or stop.

WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

Your friend is telling you about her awful week. You have five good ideas before she's finished her first sentence. You share them all. She goes quiet, then says, "Yeah, maybe." You both hang up feeling a bit worse, and you're not sure why.

Most of us want to help the people around us. But helping well is a skill, and good intentions don't always land. This chapter explains how support works, why "fixing" can backfire, and how to care for others in a way you can keep up. It's for friends, partners, parents, coworkers, carers, neighbours, and anyone who has ever wanted to help and didn't know how.

01

Ask what kind of help they want.

Help comes in different kinds. Some people want ideas. Some want someone to listen. Some want a practical hand, like a meal or a lift. Some just want company. Giving the wrong kind, even kindly, can leave someone feeling unheard. The simplest fix is to ask.

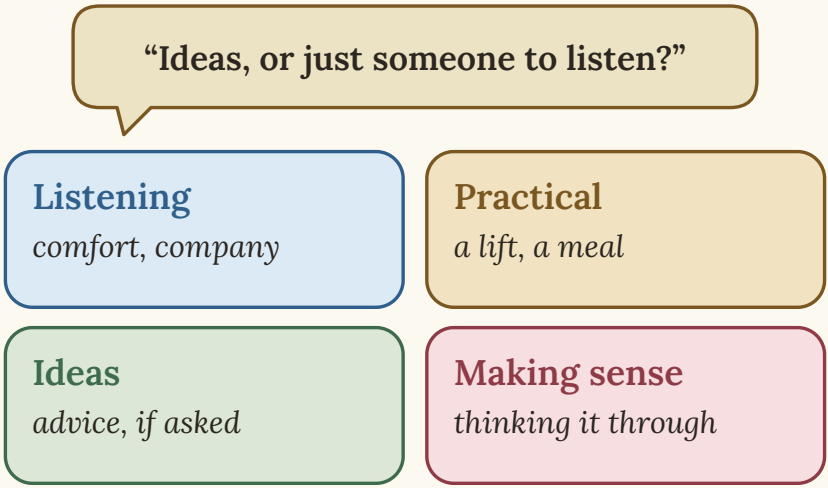
For example (a friend): In the scene above, a better start would have been: "That sounds like a rotten week. Do you want ideas, or do you just want to vent?" She would have said "vent," and the call would have gone very differently.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Do you want ideas, a listening ear, or a hand with something?"
> "What would help most right now?"

TRY THIS:
Next time someone tells you about a problem, ask what kind of help they want before you give any.

Ask what kind of help they want

The wrong kind of help can feel like not being heard.



- Fixing it for them can take away their power.
- Care from a steady place. Your limits make your help last.
- In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

Kinds of support after House (1981). Support helps most when it fits what the person needs (Cutrona and Russell, 1990), though the evidence for exact matching is mixed.

FIGURE 9 Ask what kind of help they want. Fixing it for them can take away their power, and your limits make your help last.

02

Listening is a kind of help.

Being truly heard is powerful. It helps people calm down, think more clearly, and often find their own answers. Good listening means paying attention, not interrupting, checking you understood, and showing that their feelings make sense, even if you'd feel differently.

For example (partners): Ravi comes home upset about his boss. Instead of "Just quit," his partner says: "So he criticised you in front of everyone, after you stayed late all week. No wonder you're furious." Ravi's shoulders drop. Ten minutes later, he has his own plan.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "So what happened was… Have I got that right?" "That makes sense. Anyone would feel that way."

TRY THIS:
In one conversation today, listen for two whole minutes without giving advice. Then sum up what you heard.



SUGARFOOT
Sugarfoot's tip: sometimes the best help is sitting close and listening, no fixing needed. Listening takes energy too, so check your own tank now and then.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

03

Fixing it for them can take away their power.

When we love someone, we want to make the problem go away. But doing things for people that they could do themselves can leave them feeling less capable. Helping well often means helping someone do it, not doing it for them. It respects that it's their life and their choice.

For example (a parent and a grown-up child): Rosalind's 24-year-old son is struggling with a job application. She wants to rewrite it.

Instead she asks, “Want me to read it and tell you what stands out?” He makes the changes himself, and feels proud when he gets the interview.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
“Is this mine to fix, or theirs to solve with my support?” “What do they want to do here?”

TRY THIS:
Notice the urge to fix. Before acting, ask: “Would you like me to do that, or help you do it?”

04

Care without drowning in their feelings.

Feeling someone’s pain as if it were your own can wear you out fast. Researchers separate this “empathic distress” from compassion: warm concern from a steadier place. Compassion still cares deeply. It just doesn’t require you to sink with the other person. A steady helper is more useful than a second person drowning.

For example (housemates): When Abi’s housemate went through a breakup, Abi cried every night with her and couldn’t sleep. After a week she was exhausted. She changed approach: kind and present, but also taking breaks, and reminding herself, “This is her pain. I can care without carrying all of it.”

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
“I can be with them in this without making it mine.” “I care, and I’m steady.”

TRY THIS:
After a heavy conversation, do something that brings you back to yourself: a walk, a shower, five slow breaths. It isn’t abandoning them. It’s refilling.

05

Your limits make your help last.

Saying yes to everything isn't kindness in the long run. It leads to resentment, exhaustion and, eventually, not being able to help at all. Limits tell people what you can give, so your yes means something. A kind no, with a suggestion of what you can do, is still help.

For example (siblings): Kojo's sister keeps asking to borrow money. He loves her and he's running out. He says: "I can't lend money any more. I can help you go through your bills on Sunday, if you'd like."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I can't do that, but I can do this." "I want to help, and I need to stop at nine tonight."

TRY THIS:

Write down one thing you're giving that you can't keep giving. Plan a kinder, smaller version you could offer instead.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your limits keep your help going for longer. When you need to say "not this time", the script maker helps you say no kindly, with something to offer instead.

TOOL **Say no kindly: script maker** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals

06

Notice when you're running on empty.

People who help a lot, like carers, parents, nurses, teachers and the friend everyone calls, can burn out. Signs include feeling exhausted most of the time, feeling numb or cynical about the people you help, getting ill more often, or dreading the next call. It doesn't mean you're a bad helper. It means you need help too.

For example (a carer): Helen has looked after her husband since his stroke. She snaps at him, then feels terrible. Her doctor says it

sounds like carer strain. A local carers' group and a few hours of respite each week give her back a little of herself, and she's gentler at home.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"Looking after myself is part of looking after them."

TRY THIS:
Rate your energy from 1 to 10 each evening for a week. If it's often 3 or lower, ask someone for one specific kind of help. See Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).

07

In a crisis, stay with them and bring in help.

If someone tells you they're thinking of ending their life, or you're worried they might be, it's okay to ask them directly. Research, such as a review led by Tim Dazzi (2014), suggests asking about suicide doesn't put the idea in someone's head; it can bring relief. You don't have to be their therapist. Your job is to listen, stay with them, and help them reach trained support.

For example (a coworker): A colleague says, "Sometimes I think everyone would be better off without me." Kirsty says gently: "I'm really glad you told me. Are you thinking about ending your life?" She says she's had thoughts. Kirsty stays with her and they call a crisis line together.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Are you thinking about suicide?" "I'm glad you told me. You don't have to go through this alone. Let's call someone together."

TRY THIS:

Save a crisis number in your phone now, so you have it if you ever need it. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If someone is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

08

Don't wait for someone else to step in.

When lots of people see something go wrong, each person can assume someone else will act. Psychologists call this the bystander effect. Knowing about it helps you break it. You don't have to be a hero. Small, safe actions count: asking "Are you okay?", getting staff, or calling for help.

For example (a stranger): On a train, a man is making a young woman uncomfortable. Yvonne doesn't confront him. She sits next to the woman and asks loudly, "Hi! Is this the train to Leeds?" The woman joins in the chat, and the man moves away.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Are you okay? Do you need anything?" To someone else nearby: "Can you get the driver? I'll stay here."

TRY THIS:

Think of one safe thing you could do if you saw someone in trouble in a public place: distract, get help, or check in afterwards. Having a plan makes it easier to act.

09

Let other people help you too.

Helping goes both ways. People who are good at giving help are often bad at receiving it. But letting others help is a gift to them, too: most people like being useful to someone they care about. Relationships where only one person ever helps tend to feel uneven over time.

For example (on your own, as a new parent): Nkechi kept saying, "We're fine, thanks," to every offer after the baby came. When she finally said yes to a neighbour's offer of a meal, the neighbour was delighted, and they became friends.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Yes, thank you. That would really help." "Could you do one thing for me this week?"

TRY THIS:
Say yes to the next small offer of help you get, even if you could manage without it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 14

One owner per job: sharing the care

Margaret and Alan, with their daughter Sue

One owner per job: sharing the care

Person A
Margaret

Person B
Alan

Person C
Sue

Date of this list
6 October 2026

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Medicines and the pill box (as the care team directs)	*Weekly*	0.5	*Margaret*	*Sue*	*Sue checks it on Sundays*
Book and go along to medical appointments	*As needed*	3	*Sue*	*Margaret*	*Sue drives; Mum comes too*
Insurance and paperwork	*Monthly*	1	*Alan*	*Sue*	*Dad can do this from his chair*
Night care and night-time calls	*Daily*	1	*Margaret*		*Ask the nurse about a night sitter*
Sunday call with the family	*Weekly*	0.5	*Alan*		
Book respite: a break for the main carer	*Monthly*	0.5	*Sue*		*Mum's Thursday afternoon off*
Groceries and meals	*Weekly*	2	*Sue*	*Margaret*	*Online shop, Sue orders*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
7 of 7. Every job has an owner.

Who's carrying more right now
Margaret 63% · Alan 9% · Sue 28%. Does this match what you agreed? If it doesn't match, ask which job could move first. It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

Changes to the list

Date	What changed	Who
6 Oct 2026	*Sue takes Tuesday nights from next week, so Margaret gets one full night's sleep.*	*Margaret, Alan and Sue*

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. This is about who owns each job, not medical advice.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (sharing the care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can offer help, listen well, and be honest about your limits. You can't make someone accept help, take your advice or get better on your timetable. Their life and their choices are theirs. If someone is in danger, your part is to bring in help, not to carry it alone.

THE NEXT WEDNESDAY, 7:15PM

Your friend calls again. This time you say, "Rough week? Do you want ideas, or just to talk it out?" She laughs and says, "Just talk." You listen. At the end, she says, "I think I know what I'm going to do." You didn't give her a single idea, and it was the most helpful call you've had in months.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Helping yourself counts too. Ask yourself the same question: "Do I need ideas right now, or just some rest?"
- **With a partner:** "Do you want me to help, or just to hear it?" works at home as well as anywhere.
- **Family:** Caring for a parent or a child with extra needs is long-haul help. Share the load early. See Caring for someone you love.
- **Friends:** The friend everyone calls needs someone to call too. Notice who that might be.
- **At work:** Covering for a struggling coworker is kind for a week. Longer than that, it needs a real conversation with the team. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **With strangers:** In an emergency, point to one person: "You in the blue coat, please call for help." A crowd often waits for someone else.
- **If you have ADHD:** Helping is interesting and urgent, so a fast "yes" is easy. Try "I'd like to help. Let me check my week and come back to you tonight." And ask for the practical help you need too. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"Helping means solving the problem."** Often, helping means listening, being there, or helping someone find their own answer.
- **"If I really cared, I'd feel everything they feel."** Caring from a steady place helps more and lasts longer.
- **"Good helpers never say no."** Good helpers last because they know their limits.
- **"Asking about suicide might give them the idea."** Research suggests it doesn't, and asking can help someone open up.
- **"I'll make it worse if I step in."** There are small, safe ways to help. Doing nothing often feels worse for the person in trouble.
- **"I should be able to manage without help."** Everyone needs help sometimes. Receiving it is part of a healthy relationship.

If you want to help someone else with this

This whole chapter is about helping others, so here's help for the helpers around you:

- **Notice the helpers.** The carer, the friend everyone calls, the coworker who always covers. Ask them how they are, and mean it.
- **Offer specific help.** "Can I take the kids on Saturday morning?" is easier to accept than "Let me know if you need anything."
- **Give them permission to rest.** "You're allowed a night off. I've got this."
- **If a helper seems burned out,** share Caring for someone you love or suggest they talk to a doctor.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "You look after everyone. Who looks after you?" "I'd love to do something for you this week. What would help?"

When to get more help

- **If someone is in danger now,** call your local emergency number.
- **If someone talks about suicide,** stay with them and contact a crisis line together. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.
- **If someone tells you they're being hurt or controlled at home,** believe them, don't confront the other person yourself, and share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- **If you're burned out as a helper or carer,** talk to your doctor, a carers' organisation or a counsellor. Respite and support are not luxuries.
- **If helping someone is becoming unsafe for you,** step back and bring in professionals. You can still care from a safer distance.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins), for tender conversations, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask) if you want help finding words.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Library: active listening (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/communication), advice or support? and validation.
- Library: empathic distress and compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection) and social support.

- Library: burnout (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress) and caregiver strain.
- Library: saying no and boundaries.
- Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

More for your situation

- **Carers:** Caring for someone you love · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill)
- **Friends:** Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Parents and grandparents:** For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) · For grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- **At work:** At work · For counsellors, coaches and group leaders (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

More in Part Three

← Chapter 11: Healing after hurt (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing) · Chapter 13: Anger → (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger) · All chapters in the book's contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/)

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is about everyday helping. It isn't training in crisis care or therapy. When someone's safety is at risk, the most helpful thing you can do is bring in people trained to help.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Ask what kind of help they want.** "Ideas, or just someone to listen?" saves a lot of misfires.
- ✓ **Listening is help.** Fixing it for someone can take away their power.
- ✓ **Your limits make your help last.** Caring from a steady place helps more than drowning in their feelings.
- ✓ **In a crisis, stay and bring in help.** It's okay to ask directly about suicide, and to call for help.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · The work nobody sees page 7
The care work nobody sees

Chapter 2 · Is the split working? page 27
Sharing the load so it lasts

Book 4 · Loss, grief and big life changes Understanding people
Helping someone through grief

Book 2 · Stress and the nervous system Together
Noticing your own stress first

PUT IT TO USE



Check-ins
For tender conversations, and Professor Puddles if you want help finding words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins



Stories from philosophy: the circles of Hierocles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping-in-depth

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01`
In: The work nobody sees (page **7**), Is the split working? (page **27**), The monthly look-back (page **97**)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02`
In: Is the split working? (page **27**), Full tanks and different angles (page **51**), The monthly look-back (page **97**), Helping others well (page **121**)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03`
In: Is the split working? (page **27**), Two kinds of fair (page **73**), The monthly look-back (page **97**), Helping others well (page **121**)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04`
In: The monthly look-back (page **97**)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09`
In: Two kinds of fair (page **73**)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page **51**)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page **51**)

TOOL **Say no kindly: script maker** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/refusals`
In: Helping others well (page 121)

TOOL **Weekly check-in card** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins`
In: The monthly look-back (page 97), Helping others well (page 121)

TOOL **Turn a complaint into a request** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins`
In: Two kinds of fair (page 73)

TOOL **Where a reaction comes from** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

TOOL **Who does what: chore split check** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: The work nobody sees (page 7)

TOOL **Chores and bills: count the hours and money** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand`
In: Is the split working? (page 27), Two kinds of fair (page 73)

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 51)

TOOL **Ask a question in your own words** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask`
In: Helping others well (page 121)

TOOL **Handoff-bag checklist for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`
In: The work nobody sees (page 7), Is the split working? (page 27), Full tanks and different angles (page 51), Two kinds of fair (page 73), The monthly look-back (page 97)

TOOL **Room agreement for roommates** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room`
In: The work nobody sees (page 7), Is the split working? (page 27), Full tanks and different angles (page 51), Two kinds of fair (page 73), The monthly look-back (page 97)

TOOL **10-minute team check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`
In: Is the split working? (page 27), Helping others well (page 121)

TOOL **Connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`
In: The work nobody sees (page 7), Is the split working? (page 27), Full tanks and different angles (page 51), Two kinds of fair (page 73), The monthly look-back (page 97)

TOOL **Fair split calculator** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working`
In: Is the split working? (page 27)

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The load: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
load = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means heavier**. Under 0.30 is a light load, 0.30 up to 0.60 a medium load, and 0.60 or more a high load. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left: a high load means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III, page **51**, scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is a high load.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need a light load to come back, just less than half.

Today's Weather: the room in your day

Today's Weather shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now (online), picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).

`26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

Two people. Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷
100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the load sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Part Two, Chapter II, page 27). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

Three or more people, or an agreed split. The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the
split you agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter II, page 27): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167; most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667; balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

Who carries more of the list. A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as
needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷
0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights
of all the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

Who's carrying more right now. Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the Preface, page **7**'s example, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average load) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the load. The load is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − load. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the Lemonade Stand says "holding"); 0.40 up to 0.70 as needs a look ("drifting"); below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter II, page **27**): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own load scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

The shortfall is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067; ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088; load 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the load, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a load lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

The overall score adds a fourth part, retuning: of the moments that landed badly this week, how many you retuned before answering.

```
overall = balance × 0.35 + ownership × 0.30 + (1 − load) ×
0.20 + retuning × 0.15
(no rough moments this week: leave retuning out, and divide
the first three parts by 0.85)
```

In Chapter II's first worked example (balance 0.60, ownership 0.80, an average load of 0.40, and 3 of 5 rough moments retuned): `0.21 + 0.24 + 0.12 + 0.09 = 0.66`.

The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the load, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership,
load),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller
didn't shift
```

One next step: a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's load at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

Hours to change hands over the month: for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks: hours 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12; jobs with an owner 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12; Rosemary's load 0.45, 0.50, 0.40, 0.35 and Ken's 0.30 every week; rescues 3, 2, 1, 1.

PART	START (WEEKS 1–2)	END (WEEKS 3–4)	CHANGE	READS AS
Balance	(0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79	(0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96	+0.17	Better
Ownership	0.75	0.92	+0.17	Better
Average load	0.39	0.34	−0.05	About the same
Rosemary's own load	0.48	0.38	−0.10	Lighter
Rescues a week	2.5	1	−1.5	Fewer

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The Lemonade Stand's "just me" view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. A made-up example: 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book's own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn't be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a "How is this worked out?" note.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Backstop
The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency
Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Drift
Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

Gatekeeping
Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

A kind no
A kind no says what you can and can't do right now, without blaming anyone.

Kinship care
When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book's title means just that: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

Pressure

Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes

The 90 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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